

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Indian States & Society in the Eighteenth Century - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Indian States & Society in the Eighteenth Century	
01	SCOPE, PERIODISATION AND GOVERNING DEBATE Technically, Scope, periodisation and governing debates is analysed by
02	EVIDENCE BASE, SOURCE MATRIX AND METHOD (METHOD) Every important claim should run claim - named
03	POLITICAL MAP AFTER MUGHAL WEAKENING Technically, Political map after Mughal weakening is analysed by
04	STATE FORMATION ENGINE: FISCAL, MILITARY, SOCIAL AND FINANCIAL POWER Technically, State formation engine: fiscal, military, social and
05	HYDERABAD: NIZAM-UL-MULK, MUGHAL CONTINUITY AND PRACTICAL AUTONOMY Claim: Hyderabad retained Mughal sovereignty in form while
06	BENGAL: REVENUE, COMMERCE, BANKERS AND THE PRE-PLASSEE BOUNDARY Bengal dispenses both extremes: it was neither an untouched
07	AWADH: SAADAT KHAN, SAJDAR JANG AND A FISCAL-MILITARY BUFFER The late end of century greatly owed Lucknow supported
08	MARATHA LEGACY BEFORE PESHWA EXPANSION: BOUNDED SHIVAJI, SHAHU AND After Shivaji's release in 1700, established the Maratha kingdom's control
09	PESHWA EXPANSION: BALAJI VISHWANATH, BAJI RAO I AND NANA SAHEB Technically, Peshwa expansion: Balaji Vishwanath, Bajji Rao I and
10	MARATHA CONFEDERACY, REVENUE AND ADMINISTRATION Maratha coalition revenue specialists, many of them Brahmins, could
11	PANIPAT 1761 AND POST-PANIPAT RECOVERY Maratha relations with Rajputs, Jats and Sikh chiefs had been
12	SIKH STATE FORMATION I: KHALSA LEGACY AND BANDA SINGH BAHADUR Indian commercial centres could foster stability and Mughal revenue
13	SIKH STATE FORMATION II: MISLS, DAL KHALSA AND BOUNDED RANJIT SINGH The site illustrates layered political use. It does not by itself prove the
14	MYSORE: WODEYAR INHERITANCE, HAIDAR ALI AND MILITARY FISCALISM (INTERPRETATION) Burton Stein's phrase military fiscalism captures
15	TRAVANCORE AND KERALA: CENTRALISATION, TRADE AND REGIONAL CULTURE Royal trade-related policy implemented: Mughal policies and
16	JATS, RAJPUTS, ROHILLAS, ARCOT AND OTHER REGIONAL STATES Chowhan and Bhatia Singh created Ranthambur, Suraj Mal expanded
17	SOCIETY: ELITES, ZAMINDARS, PEASANTS, CASTE, WOMEN AND MILITARY LABOUR Muslim society was also stratified by status, lineage, sect and
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19	CULTURE, LANGUAGE, ART, SCIENCE AND REGIONAL COURTS Technically, Culture, language, art, science and regional courts is
20	WARFARE, FISCAL-MILITARY CHANGE AND DIPLOMACY Warfare was an instrument of fiscal survival
21	CONTINUITY AND INNOVATION IN MUGHAL INSTITUTIONS Maratha administration in Malabar, Gujarat and Kandahar often
22	HISTORIOGRAPHY: DARK AGE, MATERIAL CRISIS, REGIONALISATION AND ECONOMIC (INTERPRETATION) Materialist work is not merely "dark history" it
23	CRISIS, TRANSITION OR REGIONAL RESURGENCE - GRADED SYNTHESIS Colonial built regional resurgence is persuasive, though concentrated
24	BRIDGE TO COLONIAL CONQUEST WITHOUT INEVITABILITY Maratha leaders, Indian empire, antiquities, revenue officials and
25	TERMINOLOGY, TIMELINE, MEMORY HOOKS, TRAPS AND ANSWER TOOLKIT Technically, Terminology, Timeline, memory hooks, traps and answer

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Question: Which classification best describes Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad in the eighteenth century?

Question: Which classification best describes Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad in the eighteenth century?

- A. Mughal successor states formed from provincial office B. Independent kingdoms outside Mughal institutions C. Uniform peasant republics D. European client states from inception

Answer: A.

Explanation: Their founders converted Mughal governorship and revenue office into practical autonomy while retaining imperial forms.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q2. Question: Which evidence most directly shows practical autonomy without a formal break in Hyderabad?

Question: Which evidence most directly shows practical autonomy without a formal break in Hyderabad?

- A. A ban on Persian administration B. Independent war and appointments alongside coin and khutba in the emperor's name C. A modern written constitution D. A permanent end to Mughal titles

Answer: B.

Explanation: The contrast between autonomous action and retained symbolism is the defining evidence.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q3. Question: The Nizamat of Arcot is best placed in which political genealogy?

Question: The Nizamat of Arcot is best placed in which political genealogy?

- A. A Rohilla state created by Durrani B. A direct Portuguese province C. A Carnatic formation emerging from the Hyderabad-Deccan hierarchy D. A Sikh misl on the Coromandel

Answer: C.

Explanation: Arcot belonged to the Carnatic political field under Hyderabad before gaining practical autonomy.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q4. Question: What does the emperor's name on a regional ruler's coin safely establish?

Question: What does the emperor's name on a regional ruler's coin safely establish?

- A. Daily fiscal control from Delhi B. Modern federal subordination C. Absence of a regional army D. A claim to Mughal legitimacy

Answer: D.

Explanation: Coin legend is strong symbolic evidence but cannot by itself prove effective administration or remittance.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q5. Question: Who founded the autonomous Asaf Jahi line conventionally dated from 1724?

Question: Who founded the autonomous Asaf Jahi line conventionally dated from 1724?

A. Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah I B. Murshid Quli Khan C. Saadat Khan Burhan-ul-Mulk D. Alivardi Khan

Answer: A.

Explanation: Nizam-ul-Mulk defeated Mubariz Khan and consolidated Hyderabad in 1724.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q6. Question: What was institutionally unusual about Murshid Quli Khan's position in Bengal in 1717?

Question: What was institutionally unusual about Murshid Quli Khan's position in Bengal in 1717?

A. He abolished land revenue B. He combined the offices of nazim and diwan C. He transferred Bengal to Awadh D. He became Mughal emperor

Answer: B.

Explanation: Combining executive and fiscal office weakened the older provincial check and strengthened autonomy.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q7. Question: Why was the house of Jagat Seth politically important in Bengal?

Question: Why was the house of Jagat Seth politically important in Bengal?

A. It founded the Wodeyar dynasty B. It administered the Sikh misls C. It linked treasury, remittance, credit and mint influence D. It commanded the Maratha confederacy

Answer: C.

Explanation: Banking power supported revenue remittance and coalition politics and later influenced succession.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q8. Question: Which sequence correctly describes Bengal before Plassey?

Question: Which sequence correctly describes Bengal before Plassey?

A. Nizam-ul-Mulk - Sarfaraz Khan - Shuja-ud-Daula - Siraj B. Saadat Khan - Safdar Jang - Alivardi Khan - Mir Qasim
C. Alivardi Khan - Murshid Quli Khan - Saadat Khan - Siraj D. Murshid Quli Khan - Shuja-ud-din - Alivardi Khan - Siraj-ud-Daula

Answer: D.

Explanation: The sequence keeps Bengal's dynastic and military transitions distinct from Awadh and Hyderabad.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q9. Question: Who founded Awadh's autonomous provincial line after appointment as governor in 1722?

Question: Who founded Awadh's autonomous provincial line after appointment as governor in 1722?

A. Saadat Khan Burhan-ul-Mulk B. Shuja-ud-Daula C. Najib-ud-Daula D. Safdar Jang

Answer: A.

Explanation: Safdar Jang was Saadat Khan's successor and later imperial wazir.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q10. Question: Which description best captures Awadh's treatment of major zamindars under Saadat Khan?

Question: Which description best captures Awadh's treatment of major zamindars under Saadat Khan?

- A. Complete zamindar independence B. Military submission followed by confirmation when dues were accepted C. Replacement by European collectors D. Universal dispossession and direct peasant ownership

Answer: B.

Explanation: Awadh centralised through controlled accommodation, not total abolition of local landed power.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q11. Canonical concept check 11

Question: In Maratha fiscal language, chauth was primarily

- A. a village irrigation cess B. a ten-percent superior deshमुख claim C. a one-fourth claim on assessed revenue, often outside the core territory D. a fixed salary to the Peshwa

Answer: C.

Explanation: Chauth and sardeshमुखी were distinct claims and did not automatically equal direct sovereignty.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q12. Canonical concept check 12

Question: Sardeshमुखी is best distinguished from chauth as

- A. a Sikh protection payment B. the Mughal land survey C. a European customs pass D. an additional one-tenth claim based on asserted superior deshमुख right

Answer: D.

Explanation: The one-tenth sardeshमुखी claim was additional to the one-fourth chauth claim.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q13. Question: What was the main significance of the 1719 Mughal-Maratha arrangement?

Question: What was the main significance of the 1719 Mughal-Maratha arrangement?

- A. It used imperial sanction to recognise Shahu's swarajya and fiscal claims B. It ended Maratha expansion permanently C. It abolished the Peshwaship D. It transferred Delhi to Hyderabad

Answer: A.

Explanation: The arrangement joined Mughal legal form to expanding Maratha power and obligations.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q14. Canonical concept check 14

Question: The Battle of Palkhed (1728) is associated with

- A. Haidar Ali defeating the Dutch B. Baji Rao I compelling Nizam-ul-Mulk to reaffirm Shahu's Deccan claims C. Alivardi defeating the Company D. Abdali defeating the Marathas

Answer: B.

Explanation: Palkhed strengthened Baji Rao and Shahu but did not settle all Deccan rivalry.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q15. Question: Which pairing of Maratha house and regional base is correct?

Question: Which pairing of Maratha house and regional base is correct?

A. Bhonsle - Arcot B. Holkar - Bengal C. Gaekwad - Baroda/Gujarat D. Scindia - Travancore

Answer: C.

Explanation: Holkar centred on Indore/Malwa, Scindia on Gwalior/north India and Bhonsle on Nagpur/eastward expansion.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q16. Canonical concept check 16

Question: Baji Rao I's expansion into Malwa and Gujarat was strategically important because it

A. removed all local zamindars B. ended the need for revenue collection C. created a unitary national state D. provided resources and placed pressure between Hyderabad and Delhi

Answer: D.

Explanation: The provinces offered wealth, routes and strategic depth; local rights and negotiation remained.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q17. Question: Which power was an important ally of Ahmad Shah Abdali at Panipat?

Question: Which power was an important ally of Ahmad Shah Abdali at Panipat?

A. Najib-ud-Daula of Rohilkhand B. Suraj Mal as a committed Maratha commander C. Murshid Quli Khan D. Martanda Varma

Answer: A.

Explanation: Abdali's coalition included Rohilla support and Shuja-ud-Daula; Maratha relations with likely northern allies had deteriorated.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q18. Canonical concept check 18

Question: The most accurate assessment of Panipat (1761) is that it

A. immediately established Company rule across India B. severely damaged Maratha northern power but did not end Maratha recovery C. created permanent Afghan rule in India D. abolished the Peshwaship

Answer: B.

Explanation: Madhav Rao restored power and Marathas returned Shah Alam II to Delhi in 1771.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q19. Question: Which event best demonstrates post-Panipat Maratha recovery?

Question: Which event best demonstrates post-Panipat Maratha recovery?

A. The founding of Jaipur in 1727 B. The execution of Banda in 1716 C. Restoration of Shah Alam II to Delhi in 1771 D. The 1717 Bengal appointment

Answer: C.

Explanation: The 1771 action shows renewed northern reach under the recovered confederacy.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q20. Question: Why is the Shahu-Tarabai contest important?

Question: Why is the Shahu-Tarabai contest important?

A. It ended local hereditary rights B. It was a British annexation dispute C. It created the Khalsa D. It enabled sardars and the Peshwa to bargain and reshape Maratha authority

Answer: D.

Explanation: The contest weakened simple dynastic command and helped produce a negotiated Peshwa-centred order.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q21. Canonical concept check 21

Question: The Khalsa was established by Guru Gobind Singh in

A. 1699 B. 1719 C. 1707 D. 1761

Answer: A.

Explanation: The 1699 foundation is the institutional legacy for eighteenth-century Sikh mobilisation.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q22. Question: Which act most clearly shows Banda Singh Bahadur moving from revolt toward state formation?

Question: Which act most clearly shows Banda Singh Bahadur moving from revolt toward state formation?

A. Founding Hyderabad B. Appointing officials and using coin and seal C. Joining the English Company D. Accepting the Peshwaship

Answer: B.

Explanation: Faujdars, diwan, kardars, coin and seal are administrative and sovereign practices.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q23. Question: Which statement about Banda Singh Bahadur's social base is most accurate?

Question: Which statement about Banda Singh Bahadur's social base is most accurate?

A. Every Khatri merchant supported him B. It had no agrarian dimension C. It included Jat peasants and smaller zamindars but was not socially unanimous D. Only Mughal nobles supported him

Answer: C.

Explanation: Peasant, zamindar and commercial interests varied, and some groups aligned with the Mughals.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q24. Question: How should the number of Sikh misls be written in an evidence-disciplined answer?

Question: How should the number of Sikh misls be written in an evidence-disciplined answer?

A. Exactly twelve unchanging units from 1699 B. All bands were provinces of Awadh C. No misls existed before 1809 D. Twelve major misls in conventional classification, with fluid contemporary groupings

Answer: D.

Explanation: The textbook twelve is useful, but boundaries and the count of territorial combinations changed over time.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q25. Canonical concept check 25

Question: The Dal Khalsa represented

A. collective Sikh mobilisation above individual misls B. the Maratha royal council C. the Bengal treasury D. the Mughal revenue ministry

Answer: A.

Explanation: It allowed joint action without eliminating misl autonomy.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q26. Question: Why is Ranjit Singh bounded in this topic?

Question: Why is Ranjit Singh bounded in this topic?

A. He fought at Panipat in 1761 B. He represents late-century consolidation after the misl phase C. He created Rohilkhand D. He founded the Khalsa in 1699

Answer: B.

Explanation: His capture of Lahore in 1799 completes a trajectory; his mature state and Anglo-Sikh context belong later.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q27. Canonical concept check 27

Question: The Mysore kingdom's historical genealogy is most closely linked to

A. the Sikh misls B. the Durrani Empire C. the Vijayanagara political order D. the Portuguese Estado da India

Answer: C.

Explanation: The Wodeyar kingdom emerged from the post-Vijayanagara regional field.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q28. Question: Which reform is associated with Haidar Ali's military consolidation?

Question: Which reform is associated with Haidar Ali's military consolidation?

A. The 1719 Maratha sanad B. Abolition of all land taxes C. Creation of the Jagat Seth bank D. A modern arsenal at Dindigul with French assistance

Answer: D.

Explanation: The Dindigul arsenal and trained units strengthened Mysore's military capability.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q29. Canonical concept check 29

Question: Tipu Sultan's later use of his own name in coinage and khutba most strongly indicates

A. a sharper assertion of sovereignty than most successor states B. membership in the Dal Khalsa C. submission to the Peshwa D. direct Mughal control

Answer: A.

Explanation: The symbolism marked a more explicit claim, though even Tipu used Mughal authority pragmatically when useful.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q30. Canonical concept check 30

Question: Martanda Varma strengthened Travancore mainly through

A. Company Diwani B. military centralisation, trade monopoly and public works C. Mughal mansabdari alone D. Sikh conquest shares

Answer: B.

Explanation: Army reform, suppression of feudatories, pepper revenue and communication works reinforced the state.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q31. Question: Who consolidated the Jat kingdom of Bharatpur at its eighteenth-century height?

Question: Who consolidated the Jat kingdom of Bharatpur at its eighteenth-century height?

A. Najib-ud-Daula B. Churaman alone C. Suraj Mal D. Nizam Ali Khan

Answer: C.

Explanation: Churaman and Badan Singh built the state; Suraj Mal expanded and centralised it.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q32. Canonical concept check 32

Question: Sawai Jai Singh II is correctly associated with

A. the Bhangi misl B. the Treaty of Mangalore C. Murshidabad's mint D. Jaipur and monumental astronomical observatories

Answer: D.

Explanation: Jaipur and Jantar Mantar provide a counter-example to blanket cultural or scientific sterility.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q33. Canonical concept check 33

Question: Rohilkhand emerged primarily from

A. Afghan military settlement amid Mughal weakening B. territory occupied and granted by Durrani C. a Portuguese coastal factory D. a Travancore succession

Answer: A.

Explanation: Durrani later allied with Rohillas; he did not found their state.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q34. Canonical concept check 34

Question: The phrase military labour market refers to

- A. European troops alone B. mobile soldiers and commanders offering service across competing courts C. unpaid village police D. a permanent caste with one ruler only

Answer: B.

Explanation: Afghans, Rajputs, Marathas, artillerymen and others moved through service networks shaped by pay and patronage.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q35. Canonical concept check 35

Question: Ijara or ijaradari was

- A. a Sikh initiation rite B. a Mughal coin legend C. revenue farming to a contractor for a fixed promised sum D. a Maratha fort category

Answer: C.

Explanation: It supplied quick cash but could intensify extraction and empower financier-collectors.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q36. Canonical concept check 36

Question: Peshkash most commonly denoted

- A. a village share of chauth B. an artillery drill C. a European sea pass D. tribute or payment acknowledging a superior authority

Answer: D.

Explanation: Peshkash could preserve a hierarchical relationship without direct daily administration.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q37. Question: What is the most accurate description of the banker-state-company relationship?

Question: What is the most accurate description of the banker-state-company relationship?

- A. A shifting triangle of credit, security, trade privilege and political leverage B. States did not need credit C. Bankers always served the Company D. Companies had no Indian partners

Answer: A.

Explanation: Bankers pursued repayment and access; their alignments varied by region and political moment.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q38. Canonical concept check 38

Question: A hundi was important because it

- A. abolished customs B. transferred credit and remittance across commercial networks C. defined a Sikh mistl D. served as a fort cannon

Answer: B.

Explanation: Hundis helped move revenue, settle accounts and finance trade and war.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q39. Question: Which set contains important eighteenth-century textile or craft centres?

Question: Which set contains important eighteenth-century textile or craft centres?

A. Lahore fort, Raigad, Arcot and Rohilkhand only B. Anandpur, Satara, Kabul and Mangalore only C. Dacca, Murshidabad, Banaras and Masulipatnam D. Panipat battlefield, Palkhed, Karnal and Plassey

Answer: C.

Explanation: Manufacturing centres were distributed across several commercial regions.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q40. Question: What happened to Bengal's trade under Maratha pressure and European expansion?

Question: What happened to Bengal's trade under Maratha pressure and European expansion?

A. Only inland trade grew B. European companies withdrew C. All trade ended permanently D. Some overland trade suffered while oceanic European trade expanded

Answer: D.

Explanation: The divergent routes illustrate why one aggregate decline claim is unsafe.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q41. Question: Which statement best captures caste and mobility in the century?

Question: Which statement best captures caste and mobility in the century?

A. Hierarchy remained strong, but service could raise selected individuals and lineages B. Caste disappeared under regional states C. Political power always followed ritual rank D. No social mobility existed

Answer: A.

Explanation: The rise of houses such as Holkar shows mobility within, not abolition of, hierarchy.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q42. Question: Why must women's history be written with explicit source limits?

Question: Why must women's history be written with explicit source limits?

A. Court chronicles provide full village data B. Elite and spectacular practices are over-recorded relative to ordinary labour C. All regions followed one matrilineal system D. Women left no historical evidence at all

Answer: B.

Explanation: Tarabai and Ahilyabai are visible, but ordinary agricultural and craft work is less fully documented.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q43. Question: Which statement about eighteenth-century political alliances is most accurate?

Question: Which statement about eighteenth-century political alliances is most accurate?

A. All wars were religious B. Only Europeans crossed religious lines C. Revenue, strategy and faction usually mattered more than communal blocs D. Hindus and Muslims never allied

Answer: C.

Explanation: Awadh-Maratha-Jat cooperation and Abdali's alliance with Rohillas and Awadh demonstrate cross-religious strategy.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q44. Question: The migration of artists from Delhi to regional courts best supports which argument?

Question: The migration of artists from Delhi to regional courts best supports which argument?

A. All Mughal art ended in 1707 B. Only European art survived C. Regional culture had no Persianate influence D. Patronage was redistributed rather than uniformly extinguished

Answer: D.

Explanation: Regional schools and courts gained talent as the imperial centre lost exclusivity.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q45. Question: Which phrase best describes institutional change in successor states?

Question: Which phrase best describes institutional change in successor states?

A. Continuity of grammar, change of authorship B. Unchanged direct rule from Delhi C. Complete administrative invention D. Modern federalism

Answer: A.

Explanation: Old vocabulary and forms survived while regional rulers, elites and financiers controlled them.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q46. Question: Which is a genuine institutional innovation of the century?

Question: Which is a genuine institutional innovation of the century?

A. Abolition of all intermediaries everywhere B. Misl conquest shares and selective direct revenue systems in Mysore C. The disappearance of coinage D. Uniform parliamentary government

Answer: B.

Explanation: Regional states adapted old systems and introduced new coalition or collection mechanisms.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q47. Canonical concept check 47

Question: A fiscal-military state is one that

A. separates taxation from war completely B. depends only on ritual authority C. turns revenue and credit into sustained military capacity D. has no merchants or officials

Answer: C.

Explanation: The revenue-army-revenue loop is central to Mysore, Awadh, Maratha and Company power.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q48. Question: Which factor most clearly distinguished the Company's later fiscal-military system?

Question: Which factor most clearly distinguished the Company's later fiscal-military system?

A. No reliance on alliances B. Absence of Indian bankers C. Exclusive use of European soldiers D. Integration of territorial revenue, corporate credit, unified command and maritime supply

Answer: D.

Explanation: The Company relied heavily on Indian sepoys, credit and allies but integrated them through a durable corporate-state structure.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q49. Question: Which statement about Panipat is the correct remedial rule?

Question: Which statement about Panipat is the correct remedial rule?

A. It checked a northern bid but Maratha power recovered B. It made Abdali emperor of India C. It immediately gave the Company the Deccan D. It ended all Maratha states

Answer: A.

Explanation: Never use Panipat as the terminal date of Maratha political power.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q50. Question: Which statement about successor-state sovereignty is correct?

Question: Which statement about successor-state sovereignty is correct?

A. Every governor issued a declaration of national independence B. Practical independence could coexist with Mughal coin, khutba and titles C. All successor states abolished Persian D. Mughal symbols prove full Delhi control

Answer: B.

Explanation: Separate formal symbolism from effective appointments, revenue and war.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q51. Question: Which is the correct chauth trap correction?

Question: Which is the correct chauth trap correction?

A. It was a Sikh protection tax B. It was identical to sardeshmukhi C. It was a fiscal claim, not ordinary direct land tax or automatic territorial rule D. It was paid only by Maratha peasants

Answer: C.

Explanation: The nature and collection of the claim varied and often preceded administration.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q52. Question: Which sequence corrects the common Sikh chronology trap?

Question: Which sequence corrects the common Sikh chronology trap?

A. Ranjit Singh - Khalsa - Banda - misls B. Misls - Khalsa - Banda - Guru Gobind Singh C. Banda - Guru Nanak - Ranjit - Khalsa D. Khalsa - Banda Singh Bahadur - misls - Ranjit Singh

Answer: D.

Explanation: Do not begin Sikh political history with Ranjit Singh.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q53. Question: Which classification correction is essential for Mysore?

Question: Which classification correction is essential for Mysore?

A. It was an older southern regional kingdom, not a Mughal successor province B. It was created by the Company C. It emerged from Rohilkhand D. It was a Maratha house

Answer: A.

Explanation: Mysore's genealogy runs through Vijayanagara and the Wodeyars.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q54. Question: Can Bengal's commercial strength prove all-India prosperity?

Question: Can Bengal's commercial strength prove all-India prosperity?

A. No; because Bengal had no trade B. No; regional evidence requires regional conclusions C. Yes; war therefore had no cost D. Yes; one surplus province fixes the national trend

Answer: B.

Explanation: The correct method is regional comparison, not aggregate projection.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q55. Question: Which statement about Jagat Seth is safest?

Question: Which statement about Jagat Seth is safest?

A. It had no relation to the Bengal treasury B. It commanded Abdali's army C. The banking house served regional fiscal power and pursued its interests; it was not a timeless Company agent D. It founded the East India Company

Answer: C.

Explanation: Banking alignments changed with security, repayment and factional politics.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q56. Question: What is the correct coin-and-khutba inference?

Question: What is the correct coin-and-khutba inference?

A. They give exact revenue totals B. They prove a ruler had no army C. They prove national sovereignty D. They show legitimacy claims, not the full reach of administration

Answer: D.

Explanation: Symbolic evidence must be paired with appointments, remittance, war and treaties.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q57. Question: Which statement corrects the 'Maratha nation' overstatement?

Question: Which statement corrects the 'Maratha nation' overstatement?

A. Maratha power was socially and regionally diverse and confederate B. Local watan rights disappeared C. Religion alone determined alliances D. Every chief obeyed one central bureaucracy

Answer: A.

Explanation: Use polity, confederacy and regional mobilisation rather than modern national homogeneity.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q58. Question: Which statement corrects a uniform claim about women?

Question: Which statement corrects a uniform claim about women?

- A. Purdah was identical across India B. Class, caste, labour and region produced sharply different experiences C. Elite rulers represent all women D. All widows could remarry

Answer: B.

Explanation: State the source base and distinguish elite visibility from ordinary work.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q59. Question: Which statement corrects the 'trade collapse' trap?

Question: Which statement corrects the 'trade collapse' trap?

- A. Only Delhi mattered B. No artisan centre survived C. Routes and towns experienced different decline, recovery and growth D. All internal and external trade stopped

Answer: C.

Explanation: War hurt some corridors while oceanic trade and regional centres expanded elsewhere.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q60. Question: Which statement corrects the inevitability trap?

Question: Which statement corrects the inevitability trap?

- A. Panipat transferred sovereignty to Britain B. Indian rulers never defeated Company forces C. Mughal decline automatically caused British rule D. Fragmentation created openings, but Company victory required later revenue, credit, alliances and war

Answer: D.

Explanation: Opportunity is not destiny; the sequence from commerce to fiscal-military state must be demonstrated.

Trap logic: Check the category, chronology, source scale and difference between legal claim, symbolic legitimacy and practical control before selecting an option.

Q61. What distinguishes a successor state from a new mobilised state?

- A. A successor state converted Mughal provincial office into autonomy, while a mobilised state grew through other armed-local routes. B. Both were modern republics. C. New states never used legitimacy. D. Successor states had no revenue systems.

Answer: A. Explanation: A successor state converted Mughal provincial office into autonomy, while a mobilised state grew through other armed-local routes.

Q62. Which is the safest description of Hyderabad after 1724?

- A. It rejected every imperial title immediately. B. It combined the Nizam's provincial-military power with retained Mughal political forms. C. It had no Deccan context. D. It was a Sikh misl.

Answer: B. Explanation: It combined the Nizam's provincial-military power with retained Mughal political forms.

Q63. What did Awadh's state formation especially require?

A. A unitary Maratha command. B. The abolition of revenue collection. C. Accommodation with local chiefs, zamindars and imperial office. D. Direct control by Persian invaders.

Answer: C. Explanation: Accommodation with local chiefs, zamindars and imperial office.

Q64. Why is Bengal's commercial wealth not a welfare statistic?

A. Artisans own all land. B. Bankers replace all rulers. C. Commerce makes war impossible. D. Trade and revenue strength can coexist with unequal social and agrarian outcomes.

Answer: D. Explanation: Trade and revenue strength can coexist with unequal social and agrarian outcomes.

Q65. Which label fits the Maratha polity best?

A. A fiscal-military confederacy with negotiated leadership and regional houses. B. A permanent Delhi province. C. A uniform central bureaucracy. D. A movement without diplomacy.

Answer: A. Explanation: A fiscal-military confederacy with negotiated leadership and regional houses.

Q66. What is a necessary caution about Sikh misls?

A. They were Mughal revenue districts. B. They were fluid armed-territorial formations rather than a timeless fixed map. C. They lacked any political role. D. They existed only after British rule.

Answer: B. Explanation: They were fluid armed-territorial formations rather than a timeless fixed map.

Q67. How should Mysore be included here?

A. As a successor province of Bengal. B. As proof every state was identical. C. As a bounded case of regional centralisation, without turning the topic into later Anglo-Mysore wars. D. As a reason to omit the Marathas.

Answer: C. Explanation: As a bounded case of regional centralisation, without turning the topic into later Anglo-Mysore wars.

Q68. What makes Jat state formation analytically distinct?

A. It ended all Mughal symbols everywhere. B. It lacked local social bases. C. It was a direct copy of Hyderabad. D. Agrarian-zamindari mobilisation and regional consolidation shaped its route.

Answer: D. Explanation: Agrarian-zamindari mobilisation and regional consolidation shaped its route.

Q69. What did merchant-bankers contribute?

A. Credit, remittance and brokerage linking rulers, markets and military finance. B. Only religious authority. C. An automatic end to peasant production. D. A replacement for all armies.

Answer: A. Explanation: Credit, remittance and brokerage linking rulers, markets and military finance.

Q70. What does a hundi primarily illustrate?

A. A caste census. B. The movement of credit and value across distance. C. A fortification type. D. A cavalry rank.

Answer: B. Explanation: The movement of credit and value across distance.

Q71. Which statement on artisans is most defensible?

A. All artisans became court officials. B. Production disappeared outside Europe. C. Skilled production and commercial links persisted, but outcomes differed by region and group. D. Craft evidence proves universal prosperity.

Answer: C. Explanation: Skilled production and commercial links persisted, but outcomes differed by region and group.

Q72. How should gender evidence be handled?

A. Only royal women worked. B. Gender had no relation to class. C. One memoir is a social census. D. Elite records show particular agency but cannot stand for all women's work or autonomy.

Answer: D. Explanation: Elite records show particular agency but cannot stand for all women's work or autonomy.

Q73. What social condition best qualifies regional resurgence?

A. Caste, class, credit and warfare produced unequal costs and opportunities. B. Political change erased hierarchy. C. Every group gained equally. D. Agriculture ceased to matter.

Answer: A. Explanation: Caste, class, credit and warfare produced unequal costs and opportunities.

Q74. What does cultural continuity mean here?

A. Only Delhi could sponsor culture. B. Patronage, languages and Persianate administrative forms adapted to regional courts. C. Political conflict erased all artistic work. D. Culture was frozen unchanged.

Answer: B. Explanation: Patronage, languages and Persianate administrative forms adapted to regional courts.

Q75. Which approach avoids the 'dark age' trap?

A. Generalise Bengal's commerce to all groups. B. Ignore warfare entirely. C. Separate imperial crisis from varied regional political, economic and cultural evidence. D. Generalise Delhi's disorder to all India.

Answer: C. Explanation: Separate imperial crisis from varied regional political, economic and cultural evidence.

Q76. What did revenue systems and armies have in common?

A. They prevented all interstate conflict. B. They made legitimacy irrelevant. C. They operated without cultivators. D. They formed a reciprocal fiscal-military mechanism mediated by local alliances and credit.

Answer: D. Explanation: They formed a reciprocal fiscal-military mechanism mediated by local alliances and credit.

Q77. Why retain Rajput states in the comparison?

A. They show older regional political fields with their own courtly, tributary and diplomatic logics. B. They make chronology unnecessary. C. They had no relation to Mughal politics. D. They were all successor states.

Answer: A. Explanation: They show older regional political fields with their own courtly, tributary and diplomatic logics.

Q78. What is the correct Company bridge?

A. Companies were absent from Indian networks. B. Regional rivalry created openings, but conquest required later Company finance, alliances and military organisation. C. Panipat immediately gave Britain India. D. Regional states automatically caused conquest.

Answer: B. Explanation: Regional rivalry created openings, but conquest required later Company finance, alliances and military organisation.

Q79. Which evidence best supports a layered sovereignty claim?

A. A battle removes all institutions. B. A title proves daily obedience. C. A ruler may retain Mughal titles while independently directing regional revenue and armies. D. A court painting fixes a border.

Answer: C. Explanation: A ruler may retain Mughal titles while independently directing regional revenue and armies.

Q80. What is the most balanced final verdict?

A. It had no institutional inheritance. B. It was only anarchy. C. It was universal prosperity. D. The century combined state formation and commercial-cultural continuity with war, extraction and uneven social outcomes.

Answer: D. Explanation: The century combined state formation and commercial-cultural continuity with war, extraction and uneven social outcomes.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART II - VERIFIED/ROUTED PYQS WITH SOLUTIONS

PYQ 01 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q48: eighteenth-century successor states

Verified question: With reference to Indian history, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. The Nizamat of Arcot emerged out of Hyderabad State.
 2. The Mysore Kingdom emerged out of Vijayanagara Empire.
 3. Rohilkhand Kingdom was formed out of the territories occupied by Ahmad Shah Durrani.
- A. 1 only
 - B. 1 and 2 only
 - C. 2 and 3 only
 - D. 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: B, 1 and 2 only. **Confidence:** high.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is correct in the conventional political genealogy: the Carnatic or Nizamat of Arcot developed within the Deccan-Hyderabad hierarchy before its Nawabs gained practical autonomy.
- Statement 2 is correct: the Wodeyar kingdom of Mysore grew from the political field of the Vijayanagara Empire.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: Rohilkhand grew from Afghan military settlement and weakening Mughal authority; Ahmad Shah Durrani later allied with Rohilla power but did not create the state from occupied territory.
- The question tests origin, not merely chronology. It distinguishes successor/subordinate formations from a later invader's sphere.

Why this earns marks: It tests each statement independently, names the predecessor polity, corrects the backward projection of Durrani and labels the answer as inferred because the local official key is unavailable.

PYQ 02 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45: Mughal administrative hierarchy

Verified question: With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in ascending order in terms of size?

- A. Pargana - Sarkar - Suba
- B. Sarkar - Pargana - Suba
- C. Suba - Sarkar - Pargana
- D. Pargana - Suba - Sarkar

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: A, Pargana - Sarkar - Suba. **Confidence:** high.

Solved explanation

- A pargana grouped villages and was the smaller revenue-administrative unit in this sequence.
- A sarkar grouped parganas.
- A subah was the larger province containing sarkars.
- The hierarchy matters for Topic 02 because regional states usually appropriated Mughal territorial and fiscal machinery rather than creating administration from nothing.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact ascending sequence and links the recall fact to institutional continuity, the analytical core of successor-state formation.

PYQ 03 - 2022 GS-I Mains Q2: Company armies and Indian rulers

Verified adjacent question: Why did the armies of the British East India Company - mostly comprising Indian soldiers - win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers? Give reasons. (10 marks, 150 words)

Routing note: The direct owner is Modern History Topic 05. It is included here because Topic 02 explains the multi-state fiscal-military field from which the Company emerged. The answer must not treat fragmentation as automatic defeat.

Model answer

The Company's advantage lay less in the ethnicity of its soldiers than in the organisation that made them a reliable fiscal-military force. Indian states possessed capable cavalry, artillery and revenue systems: Mysore created French-trained infantry, Ibrahim Khan Gardi served the Marathas, and Ranjit Singh later built a disciplined army. The issue was consistency.

The Company combined regular drill, infantry-artillery coordination, unified command and reliable payment. Coastal bases and the British naval network sustained supply. London credit and Indian bankers financed long campaigns, while diplomacy isolated opponents: Mysore, Maratha and Sikh forces were usually fought in separate wars with Indian allies on the Company side. After **Plassey (1757)** and especially the **Diwani (1765)**, Bengal revenue funded troops and further conquest.

Yet victory was contingent: Haidar Ali reached Madras, the Treaty of Mangalore was negotiated, the First Anglo-Maratha War ended at Salbai, and Punjab remained independent under Ranjit Singh. The decisive edge was the cumulative integration of command, credit, revenue, supply and alliance, not inherent European superiority.

Why this earns marks: It answers "why" through linked mechanisms, uses named counter-evidence, distinguishes capability from identity and ends with a qualified causal verdict.

PYQ coverage conclusion

The audited repository routes one directly relevant successor-state Prelims question and one administrative-inheritance question. No direct GS-I Mains question confined to eighteenth-century regional states appears in the audited 2018-2025 route. The verified 2022 Company-armies question is therefore included only as an explicitly bounded bridge. No History Optional or unofficial coaching question is presented as a UPSC PYQ.

PART IV - ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Mains 10M-1 - Classify the major eighteenth-century Indian states and explain why the classification matters. (150 words)

Model answer

Eighteenth-century states are best classified by **origin and legitimacy**, not by a simple strong/weak scale.

Mughal successor states - Bengal under Murshid Quli Khan, Awadh under Saadat Khan and Hyderabad under Nizam-ul-Mulk - converted provincial office into hereditary autonomy. They retained Mughal titles, Persian administration and often coin/khutba symbolism, but controlled appointments, revenue and war locally.

Resistance or confederate states - Marathas, Sikhs, Jats and Rohillas - grew through armed mobilisation, local landed groups and new fiscal claims. The 1719 Maratha sanads legalised chauth/sardeshmukhi, while Banda Singh Bahadur's officials, coin and seal and the later Sikh misls reveal different routes from resistance to rule.

Older autonomous regional kingdoms - Mysore, Travancore and major Rajput states - strengthened pre-existing polities. Haidar Ali's arsenal and Martanda Varma's army and pepper monopoly show more explicit centralisation.

The classification matters because origin shaped political resources and weaknesses: successor states borrowed imperial legitimacy, confederacies traded unity for reach, and older kingdoms could innovate but still had to bargain with local elites. It therefore explains both regional vitality and the absence of one uncontested Mughal replacement.

Why this earns marks: It defines the classification criterion, names three evidence-rich categories, analyses why origin mattered and avoids equating autonomy with modern nation-state sovereignty.

Mains 10M-2 - Hyderabad represented continuity in form and autonomy in substance. Examine. (150 words)

Model answer

Hyderabad under **Nizam-ul-Mulk Asaf Jah I** illustrates how Mughal political grammar survived after imperial command weakened.

Continuity in form remained visible in coins struck in the emperor's name, the emperor's place in the khutba, Persian chancery practice and the continued use of mansab, jagir and peshkash. These forms gave a former imperial noble recognised legitimacy among Deccan chiefs and service elites.

Autonomy in substance followed the defeat of Mubarez Khan and consolidation in **1724**. Asaf Jah conducted wars and treaties, conferred mansabs and made major appointments without seeking effective approval from Delhi. Revenue served the Hyderabad treasury and army; local rulers paid tribute to the Nizam.

Yet the state was not fully centralised. Bandyopadhyay notes that traders, moneylenders, military aristocrats and revenue farmers remained powerful; jagirs became more hereditary and power stayed widely diffused. Post-1748 succession conflict further exposed this limitation.

Thus Hyderabad was neither a loyal province nor a modern sovereign nation-state. It was a regional patron-client order that used Mughal symbolism to legitimise practical independence.

Why this earns marks: It answers both halves of the formulation, uses coin/khutba and independent appointments as paired evidence, and qualifies autonomy with the state's diffused internal structure.

Mains 10M-3 - The Third Battle of Panipat was a grave Maratha setback, not the end of Maratha power. Explain. (150 words)

Model answer

Panipat on **14 January 1761** destroyed a major Maratha expeditionary force and sharply reduced Peshwa prestige, but it did not terminate Maratha power.

The setback was strategic. **Sadashiv Rao Bhau**, Vishwas Rao and many experienced commanders were lost; long supply lines, factional command and damaged relations with Rajputs, Jats and Sikh chiefs left the army isolated.

Ahmad Shah Abdali, by contrast, secured Rohilla support and Shuja-ud-Daula's alliance. The defeat therefore exposed coalition and logistics failure rather than the absence of trained infantry: **Ibrahim Khan Gardi** commanded a European-style force.

Its limits are equally clear. Abdali did not establish durable Indian rule. Under **Madhav Rao I (1761-72)** the Marathas defeated the Nizam, pressured Haidar Ali and recovered north Indian influence. In **1771** they restored Shah Alam II to

Delhi. Later Scindia power again dominated imperial politics.

Panipat ended the immediate bid for northern paramountcy and created openings for rivals, including the Company. It did not abolish the confederacy; the decisive British-Maratha struggle still lay ahead.

Why this earns marks: It separates battlefield loss, political consequence and later recovery, names commanders and the 1771 evidence, and rejects both terminal and inevitability claims.

Mains 15M-1 - Compare state formation in Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad. (250 words)

Model answer

Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad were all Mughal successor states, but they converted provincial office into autonomy through different coalitions and regional constraints.

Common inheritance: Each founder was an imperial servant. Murshid Quli Khan in Bengal, Saadat Khan in Awadh and Nizam-ul-Mulk in Hyderabad retained Persian administration, titles and Mughal legitimacy. None began with a modern declaration of independence. Their common mechanism was to redirect provincial revenue, appointments and military force from Delhi toward a regional treasury and dynasty.

Bengal - fiscal-commercial coalition: Murshid Quli combined nazim and diwan authority in 1717, enforced revenue through large zamindars and sustained remittance. Commerce in textiles and oceanic trade elevated merchants and bankers; the **Jagat Seth** house became provincial treasurer in 1730. Alivardi Khan's rise with landed and banking support shows both strength and coalition dependence. Maratha raids and growing European privilege were the major vulnerabilities.

Awadh - landed-military accommodation: Saadat Khan subdued rebellious zamindars but usually confirmed them after securing payment. A provincial fiscal establishment detached revenue from Delhi, while Indian Muslim, Afghan and Hindu elites and a rich military labour market supported the state. Safdar Jang's use of Maratha and Jat allies shows pragmatic coalition-building. Refractory chiefs remained a recurring constraint.

Hyderabad - patron-client Deccan order: Asaf Jah's victory in 1724 created practical autonomy while coin and khutba retained the emperor. Local chiefs paid peshkash; traders, moneylenders, revenue farmers and military aristocrats remained co-sharers. Diffused authority and post-1748 succession conflict limited centralisation.

Therefore the three shared Mughal institutional grammar but differed in social base: Bengal was most commercially financed, Awadh most dependent on landed-military accommodation, and Hyderabad most visibly a diffused Deccan patron-client system.

Why this earns marks: It compares through common criteria - legitimacy, revenue, elite coalition and weakness - rather than narrating three states separately, and uses named institutions and bankers.

Mains 15M-2 - Assess the Maratha polity under the Peshwas as a fiscal-military confederacy. (250 words)

Model answer

Under the Peshwas the Maratha polity became a far-reaching fiscal-military confederacy: its decentralisation enabled expansion but obstructed stable paramountcy.

Fiscal foundation: The **1719 sanads** recognised Shahu's swarajya and claims to **chauth** and **sardeshmukhi** in the Deccan. Balaji Vishwanath distributed collection spheres among sardars, who retained large shares to maintain troops. This converted military initiative into recurring fiscal claims, but also made the Raja and Peshwa dependent on autonomous collectors.

Political centre: Baji Rao I (1720-40) made the Peshwaship hereditary in practice and the focal point of patronage. Palkhed (1728) checked Nizam-ul-Mulk, while expansion into Malwa and Gujarat added resources and strategic depth. After Shahu's death in 1749, Nana Saheb shifted effective government to Poona.

Confederate structure: Gaekwad, Holkar, Scindia and Bhonsle houses built personal armies and regional fiscal bases. In core areas civilian revenue officers developed more regular administration; elsewhere tribute and negotiated rights preceded direct governance. Watan and deshmukh rights survived, while saranjams rewarded service.

Strength: The system mobilised cavalry and local entrepreneurship over a vast area at relatively low central cost. It adapted Mughal legal vocabulary and employed trained infantry and artillery, as shown by Ibrahim Khan Gardi.

Weakness: Rival houses, uneven remittance, thin administration and poor coalition management undermined unified strategy at Panipat. Yet Madhav Rao's recovery and the restoration of Shah Alam II in 1771 show that confederacy was not simple collapse.

The Maratha order was therefore neither a unitary empire nor mere raiding. It was an effective expansion system whose fiscal decentralisation outpaced political integration.

Why this earns marks: It connects revenue measures to armies and houses, balances efficiency with strategic cost, and uses 1719, Palkhed, Panipat and 1771 as a causal sequence.

Mains 15M-3 - Trace Sikh political transformation from the Khalsa to the misls. (250 words)

Model answer

Sikh political transformation in the eighteenth century was a non-linear movement from disciplined community to territorial revolt and then to decentralised confederate power.

Khalsa foundation: In **1699**, Guru Gobind Singh established the Khalsa, using initiation and visible discipline to strengthen a distinctive armed community. After his death in 1708, authority was located in the Panth and Granth traditions rather than another personal Guru. Not all Sikhs were Khalsa, and Jat peasants, Khatri traders and other groups had different interests.

Banda Singh Bahadur: Banda mobilised many Jat peasants and smaller zamindars under severe fiscal pressure. His movement crossed the line from rebellion toward state formation: he appointed faujdars, a diwan and kardars, issued orders under a seal and minted coin. Yet support was uneven. Some Jat zamindars and Khatri commercial-revenue interests sided with Mughal authority. Mughal pressure and internal division culminated in his capture in 1715 and execution in 1716.

Misl phase: Sikh bands survived persecution and expanded amid the disruption caused by Nadir Shah and Ahmad Shah Abdali. Territorial gains were distributed in pattis according to contribution. The later conventional classification identifies twelve major misls, but contemporary combinations were fluid. The **Dal Khalsa** enabled collective action above individual misls without abolishing chiefly autonomy.

Direction of change: The order mixed an egalitarian co-sharing ideal with the growing power of chiefs. This decentralised structure resisted Afghan control but could not produce permanent unified command. Ranjit Singh's capture of Lahore in 1799 therefore marks a later turn toward monarchy, not the starting point of Sikh politics.

Why this earns marks: It traces institutions and social bases rather than a ruler list, reconciles the twelve-misl shorthand with source fluidity, and keeps Ranjit Singh within a clear boundary.

Mains 20M-1 - Was the eighteenth century a dark age, a transition or an age of regional resurgence? Critically discuss. (250 words)

Model answer

No single label fits the eighteenth century because political, economic, social and cultural change moved at different speeds and varied sharply by region.

Why "dark age" has force: Mughal central command contracted; Nadir Shah and Abdali exposed frontier weakness; Panipat destroyed an experienced Maratha force; Bengal faced repeated Maratha raids; revenue farming and armies increased pressure on cultivators. Delhi, Lahore, Mathura, Surat and other centres suffered episodes of plunder. Older imperial histories rightly identify real war, fiscal stress and insecurity.

Why it is insufficient: Regional states retained capacity. Murshid Quli Khan's Bengal maintained a powerful revenue-commercial coalition; Saadat Khan and Safdar Jang consolidated Awadh; Asaf Jah made Hyderabad autonomous; Haidar Ali built an arsenal and disciplined army; Martanda Varma combined military reform with pepper revenue and public works. Jaipur's planned city and Jantar Mantar and the shift of artists to Lucknow, Hyderabad and other courts show cultural vitality.

Transition in institutions: Mughal forms survived even where Mughal control did not. Coin and khutba, Persian chancery, nazim-diwan offices, jagir, zamindar and revenue vocabulary continued, but regional rulers, bankers and local elites controlled them. Maratha chauth/sardeshmukhi, Sikh misls and Mysore's direct revenue experiments also changed the content of state power.

Regional resurgence with social limits: Trade, textiles, hundi finance and oceanic commerce remained vigorous in several zones. Yet a prosperous Bengal merchant or Mysore cultivator cannot stand for all India. Peasants, artisans and women experienced outcomes according to war corridor, caste, tenure and patronage.

Historiography: Materialist interpretations explain agrarian and jagirdari stress; regional and revisionist work by Muzaffar Alam, C.A. Bayly and others explains new provincial wealth and coalitions. Each is strongest at a different scale.

The graded verdict is therefore: **crisis of imperial centralisation, transition of institutions, and selective regional resurgence under unequal social conditions.**

Why this earns marks: It tests all three labels across dimensions, uses eight named regional examples, represents competing historiographies fairly and gives a scale-specific verdict rather than an artificial compromise.

Mains 20M-2 - Examine society and economy in eighteenth-century India with attention to regional variation. (250 words)

Model answer

Eighteenth-century society and economy combined commercial resilience with fiscal coercion and durable hierarchy; regional evidence does not support either nationwide collapse or nationwide prosperity.

Agriculture and revenue: Cultivation remained the chief revenue base. In Bengal, Awadh-Banaras and parts of the south, reclamation, monetisation and surplus supported states. Yet zamindars, jagirdars, revenue farmers and officials competed over the cultivator's surplus. War, ijara and irregular exactions could worsen insecurity even where output grew. Productivity and peasant welfare must therefore be separated.

Crafts and towns: Cotton and silk textiles, saltpetre, indigo, arms, metalwork and shipbuilding remained significant. Dacca, Murshidabad, Patna, Banaras, Lucknow, Masulipatnam and southern centres continued production. Some older cities and routes suffered plunder, while new regional capitals such as Lucknow, Poona, Jaipur and Hyderabad attracted artisans and officials. Urban change was redistribution, not a single decline curve.

Trade and finance: European companies imported bullion for Indian goods and expanded oceanic commerce, while Hindu, Muslim and Armenian merchants remained important. The Jagat Seth house linked Bengal's treasury, mint and remittance; hundis moved credit across regions. But European fortified factories and privilege gave commerce an increasingly coercive political edge.

Social structure: Zamindars ranged from local intermediaries to rajas; peasants were differentiated by rights and resources. Caste remained strong, though military and fiscal service enabled mobility, as the Holkar rise shows. Muslim society also had status, sect and occupational hierarchy. Tarabai and Ahilyabai reveal elite female agency, while peasant women worked in fields and crafts; neither evidence justifies a uniform gender claim.

Culture and community: Cross-religious service and shared Persianate-vernacular worlds continued, but "composite culture" did not erase caste or elite control.

Thus the economy was regionally resilient and socially unequal: state formation created markets and careers while often transferring its fiscal cost downward.

Why this earns marks: It integrates agriculture, crafts, finance, towns, caste and gender; names regional evidence; and repeatedly qualifies aggregate claims and source visibility.

Mains 20M-3 - How did eighteenth-century state formation prepare the ground for Company expansion without making conquest inevitable? (250 words)

Model answer

Eighteenth-century state formation created a competitive fiscal-military field into which European companies could enter, but Company conquest required later, contingent advantages.

Openings created by regional politics: Succession disputes in Hyderabad and the Carnatic allowed French and English companies to sell troops and install clients. Bengal's Nawabs confronted fortified factories and the abuse of the 1717 trade privilege. Maratha, Awadh, Rohilla and Rajput rivalries produced repeated alliance markets. Mobile sepoys, gunners and commanders and Indian bankers made military intervention possible.

Financial connection: Regional states depended on credit, remittance and revenue contractors. The Jagat Seths in Bengal and hundi networks demonstrate the centrality of finance. Companies entered this world as merchants and creditors, then combined contracts with armed force.

Company differentiation: Its later advantage was cumulative integration: unified command, regular payment, artillery-infantry drill, coastal supply, British naval protection, London and Indian credit, and diplomacy that isolated opponents. After Plassey and especially the **Diwani of 1765**, Bengal revenue financed purchases and new wars, turning a company into a territorial fiscal-military state.

Why defeat was not predetermined: Indian states adapted. Haidar Ali created a modern arsenal and defeated Company forces; the Second Anglo-Mysore War ended at the Treaty of Mangalore. The First Anglo-Maratha War ended in the negotiated Treaty of Salbai, and Punjab remained independent under Ranjit Singh. Panipat did not transfer India to Britain.

Structural weakness without teleology: Confederacies faced coordination problems, successor states depended on elite coalitions, and no stable all-India alliance emerged. Yet these were vulnerabilities, not a timetable for conquest.

Therefore regionalisation supplied opportunities and Indian resources, while British supremacy resulted from specific victories, Bengal finance, corporate-state organisation and Indian collaboration. The bridge was real; inevitability was not.

Why this earns marks: It answers both the enabling and anti-inevitability halves, names succession, banking, Diwani and Indian counter-successes, and explains mechanism rather than moralising about unity.